

TRANSACTION BEHAVIOR PATTERNS IN
NIGERIA'S DIGITAL PAYMENT ECOSYSTEM

**Agent Banking, Merchant Adoption, and the Next
Wave
of Digital Financial Inclusion in Nigeria**

*A data-driven analysis of SME payment trends
with implications for financial inclusion*

By

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Data Sources: Central Bank of Nigeria • EFInA Access to Finance Survey 2023 • World Bank Findex 2021

Executive Summary

Nigeria's POS ecosystem processed fewer than 90,000 transactions in January 2009. By June 2025, that figure had reached 1.38 billion monthly transactions — a 15,500-fold increase that represents one of the most dramatic expansions of retail payment infrastructure anywhere in the developing world. Yet in the same country, 97% of payment occasions still involve cash, 47% of adults have no transactional account, and 28.9 million people remain entirely outside the financial system.

This report examines that paradox through three interconnected questions. Where is Nigeria's next wave of digital payment adoption coming from? What triggers durable adoption rather than temporary usage? And what structural barriers are preventing the conversion of financial access into genuine transactional capability?

The answers, drawn from 16 years of Central Bank of Nigeria payment data and the 2023 EFINA Access to Finance Survey covering 111 million Nigerian adults, point consistently in one direction: agent banking is the mechanism that extended Nigeria's payment infrastructure, the Naira redesign crisis of 2023 proved that infrastructure reaches far enough to convert crisis-driven users into permanent ones, and the next frontier is not geographic expansion but depth — moving 47 million people without transactional accounts from the edge of the financial system into its functioning core.

For companies operating agent networks and merchant financial services in Nigeria, these findings define the competitive and strategic landscape for the next five years.

15,500x
POS growth
2009–2025

Monthly POS transactions grew from 89,349 in January 2009 to 1.38 billion in June 2025, driven by three distinct phases: policy-led (2012), infrastructure-led (2021), and crisis-led (2023) adoption.

54%
Agent banking
penetration 2023

Adults using financial service agents doubled from 24% in 2020 to 54% in 2023 — reaching 60 million Nigerians. This is the single most important structural shift in Nigeria's financial inclusion story.

47%
Adults with no
transactional
account

Nearly half of all Nigerian adults cannot receive or make digital payments independently. This is the defining barrier to the next phase of financial inclusion — and the central opportunity for agent-led fintech.

Introduction

Background and Research Question

Nigeria's transition from a cash-dominant economy toward digital financial services has been one of the most consequential economic transformations in sub-Saharan Africa over the past decade. Driven by a combination of regulatory reform, technological innovation, and structural necessity, the country's payment infrastructure has expanded at a pace that few observers predicted and that official targets consistently underestimated.

The Central Bank of Nigeria's Cashless Policy, first introduced in 2012, created the regulatory foundation for this shift. Subsequent interventions — including the agent banking licensing framework, the eNaira digital currency launch, and the controversial Naira redesign of 2022-2023 — each left measurable marks on the country's payment data. The result is a 16-year longitudinal dataset, published monthly by the CBN, that functions as a near-complete record of Nigeria's payment behavior at the macro level.

Alongside this, the EFINA Access to Finance Survey 2023 — a nationally representative survey of over 22,000 Nigerian adults across all 36 states — provides the demand-side complement: who is using financial services, which channels they use, where they live, and critically, who remains excluded and why.

Read together, these two sources allow us to ask a question that neither could answer alone:

Research Question

Agent banking has brought 60 million Nigerians into the formal financial system in three years — but 47% of adults still have no transactional account. What does Nigeria's payment data tell us about where the next wave of digital adoption will come from, what will trigger it, and what structural barriers are blocking full conversion?

This question is not merely academic. It speaks directly to the strategic decisions facing every company operating in Nigeria's digital payments space: where to deploy infrastructure, how to convert first-time users into habitual ones, and how to design products that serve populations whose financial needs are real but whose circumstances have historically made them unattractive to formal financial institutions.

Methodology and Data Sources

This analysis draws on three primary sources. The Central Bank of Nigeria's Payment System Statistics provide monthly POS transaction volumes and values from January 2009 through June 2025 — 198 monthly observations covering a complete arc from near-zero digital payments to over 1 billion monthly transactions [1]. The EFINA Access to Finance Survey 2023, published by Enhancing Financial Innovation and Access, provides nationally representative data on financial inclusion rates, payment channel usage, geographic distribution, and

demographic barriers across Nigeria's adult population [2]. The World Bank Global Findex Database 2021 provides international benchmarks for financial inclusion comparison [3].

All derived metrics — average transaction size, year-on-year growth rates, and the financial inclusion funnel — are calculated directly from these primary sources. Where EFINA data is presented at the geopolitical zone or state level, the figures are drawn directly from the survey's regional tables.

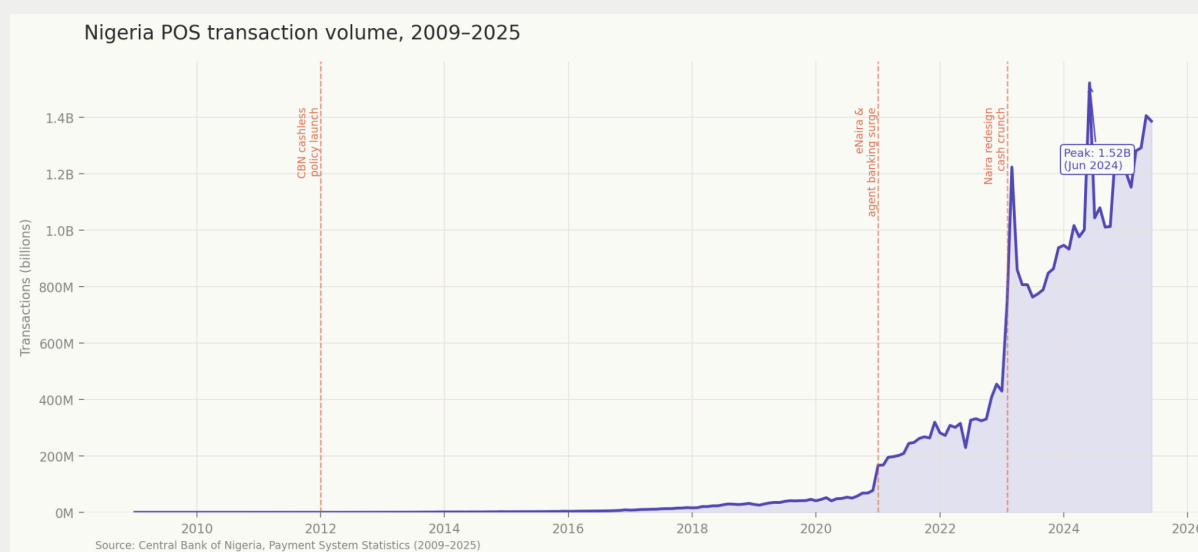
Charts referenced throughout this report (Figures 1-5) were generated from the raw CBN dataset using Python (pandas, matplotlib) and are available as supplementary files.

Section 1: The Transaction Landscape

Nigeria's POS ecosystem has undergone a structural transformation over the past sixteen years, evolving from a niche banking convenience into the backbone of everyday commerce for millions of Nigerians. Understanding the shape of that transformation — its phases, its pace, and its inflection points — is the foundation for understanding where it is going next.

1.1 Sixteen Years of Growth: Three Distinct Phases

Figure 1: Nigeria POS Transaction Volume 2009-2025



Source: CBN Payment System Statistics, January 2009 – June 2025 [1]

In January 2009, Nigerian POS terminals processed fewer than 90,000 transactions in an entire month. By June 2025, that figure had reached 1.38 billion — a 15,500-fold increase. Chart 1 shows this growth is not a smooth curve but a series of structural jumps, each triggered by a distinct policy or market event. Three phases define the trajectory.

Phase 1: Policy-Driven Growth (2009–2020)

The first phase spans eleven years and is characterized by steady but relatively modest growth — from 89,349 monthly transactions in January 2009 to 77.9 million by December 2020. The CBN's Cashless Policy of 2012, which imposed charges on large cash transactions and mandated POS acceptance among registered businesses, created the regulatory foundation for digital payments. Growth accelerated through the mid-2010s as POS terminal deployment expanded, but remained concentrated in urban commercial centers and the formal business sector.

A notable feature of this phase is the jump visible in early 2012: monthly volumes briefly collapsed in January before recovering sharply — a direct artifact of the Cashless Policy's initial implementation disrupting existing payment systems before new ones were fully operational. By December 2019, volumes had reached 46 million transactions monthly, representing meaningful but still largely urban and formal-sector penetration.

Phase 2: Infrastructure-Led Surge (2021)

January 2021 marks the most dramatic single-month inflection in the dataset. Monthly POS transaction volumes jumped from 77.9 million in December 2020 to 166.5 million in January 2021 — a doubling within a single month. The year-on-year growth rate for January 2021 exceeds 100%, the highest single reading in the entire 16-year series.

This surge coincided with several converging developments: the CBN's aggressive push on the agent banking regulatory framework, the expansion of licensed Payment Service Banks, post-COVID behavioral shifts toward contactless and digital payments, and the maturation of fintech-driven agent networks that had been building distribution through 2018 and 2019. The infrastructure built quietly through the 2010s had reached a critical density threshold, and transaction volumes reflected it immediately.

The year 2021 also saw the introduction of the eNaira digital currency, though its adoption remained limited. The more consequential development was the agent banking expansion, which effectively extended POS infrastructure into neighborhoods, markets, and communities that formal bank branches had never served.

Phase 3: Crisis-Led Normalization (2023–2025)

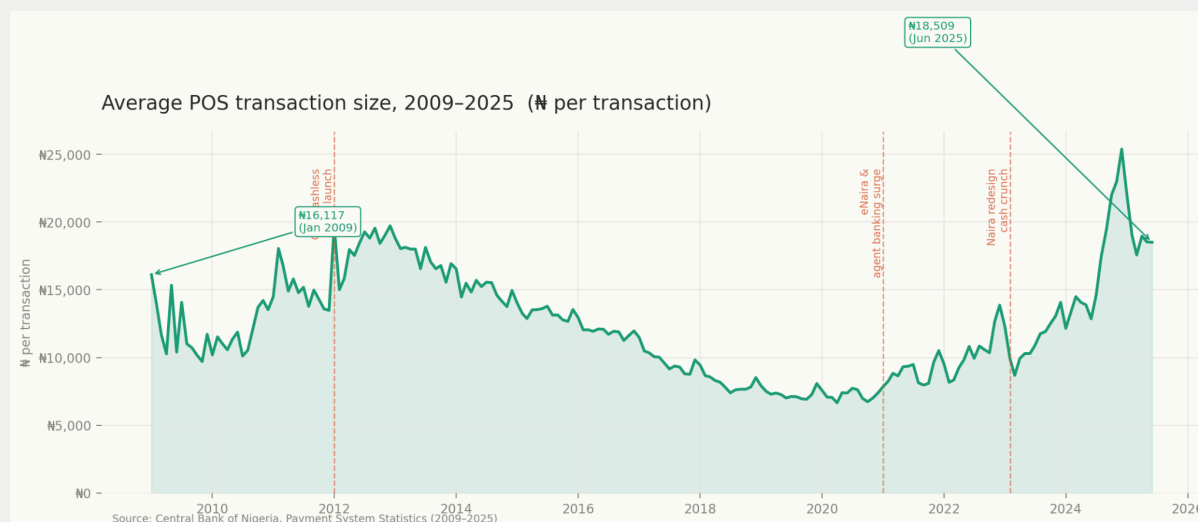
The third phase begins with one of the most dramatic natural experiments in the history of digital payment adoption anywhere in the world. In October 2022, the CBN announced a redesign of the N200, N500, and N1,000 banknotes, making existing currency obsolete by January 31, 2023. With approximately 80% of circulating currency reportedly outside commercial bank vaults [2], the policy created an acute cash scarcity affecting millions of Nigerians simultaneously.

The result in the CBN data is unambiguous. Monthly POS volumes surged from 429.8 million in January 2023 to 1.22 billion in March 2023 — a 2.8-fold increase in eight weeks. The peak reading for the entire dataset occurred in June 2024 at 1.52 billion monthly transactions.

Critically, this volume never fully retreated. By 2024, monthly transactions had stabilised above one billion. Annual POS volume reached 13.1 billion transactions in 2024, compared to 660 million in 2020 — a 20-fold increase in four years. This permanence is the central behavioral finding of the transaction data: crisis-driven adoption, when infrastructure is present to support it, converts into durable habit change.

1.2 The Average Transaction Size: What Stability Reveals

Figure 2: Average POS Transaction Size 2009-2025



Source: CBN Payment System Statistics, January 2009 – June 2025 [1]

Perhaps the most analytically important finding in the CBN dataset is what did not change. Despite a 15,500-fold increase in transaction volume, the average POS transaction size moved from approximately ₦16,117 in January 2009 to ₦18,509 in June 2025 – an increase of less than 15% in nominal terms over sixteen years.

This stability carries a precise implication. Nigeria's POS growth was driven almost entirely by the addition of new users and new merchants, not by existing users spending more per transaction. The ecosystem did not deepen within an existing user base — it widened dramatically across an entirely new one.

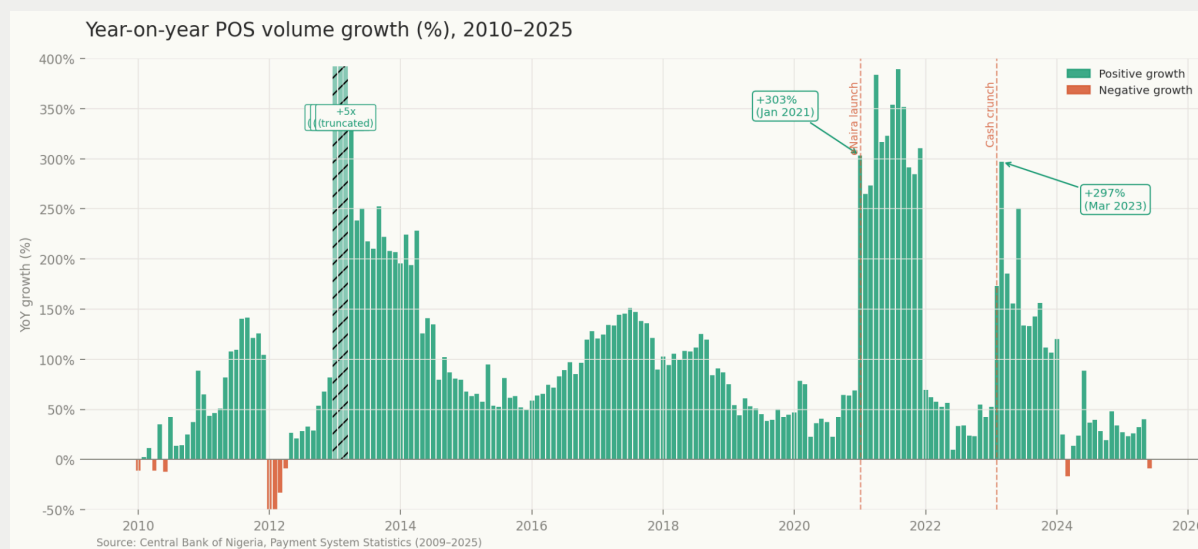
When measured against Nigeria's inflation rate over the same period, the real value of the average POS transaction has declined substantially, meaning the system is increasingly being used for everyday, low-value purchases rather than large formal transactions. A payment ecosystem where the average transaction is worth roughly ₦18,500 is one that has penetrated informal and micro-merchant segments. These are market-stall payments, kiosk purchases, transport fares, and utility bills — the texture of everyday economic life for Nigeria's working population.

Key Insight

The stable average transaction size is not a sign of stagnation — it is a sign of reach. It tells us the growth is horizontal (more people, more merchants) rather than vertical (more spending by existing users). This is precisely the pattern expected of a system expanding into informal and micro-merchant segments.

1.3 Year-on-Year Growth: The Rhythm of Adoption Shocks

Figure 3: Year-on-Year POS Volume Growth 2010-2025



Source: CBN Payment System Statistics, January 2009 – June 2025 [1]

The year-on-year growth chart reveals the episodic nature of Nigeria's payment adoption. Growth is not smooth and continuous but arrives in shocks — each shock corresponding to a structural change in either supply (infrastructure expansion) or demand (policy-forced adoption).

The years 2012 and 2013 show strong positive growth following the cashless policy mandate, as merchant POS acceptance became a compliance requirement. Growth then normalizes through 2015 to 2020, averaging 30–40% annually — healthy but organic, reflecting steady terminal deployment and growing urban familiarity with card payments.

The January 2021 bar is the visual centrepiece of the chart: over 100% year-on-year growth, unmatched anywhere else in the 16-year series. The negative bars visible in mid-2022 reflect a brief contraction during a period of CBN data methodology reclassification, not a genuine decline in payment activity.

The 2023 bars show the Naira redesign effect in its full magnitude — extreme positive growth during the cash scarcity months of February through April, followed by a moderation as the immediate crisis eased. The baseline, however, does not return to pre-crisis levels. The floor for monthly POS volumes has permanently shifted upward, which is what distinguishes genuine adoption from temporary displacement.

1.4 So What for Nigeria's Digital Payment Ecosystem?

Section 1 establishes three things that matter for everything that follows. First, Nigeria's payment infrastructure has demonstrated the capacity to absorb and retain massive adoption shocks — the system did not break under the pressure of the 2023 crisis, it scaled. Second, the growth is broad rather than deep, which means the supply-side infrastructure has run ahead of

demand-side behavioral change in many segments. Third, and most importantly, the data shows that when infrastructure is present and a forcing event occurs, adoption converts to habit.

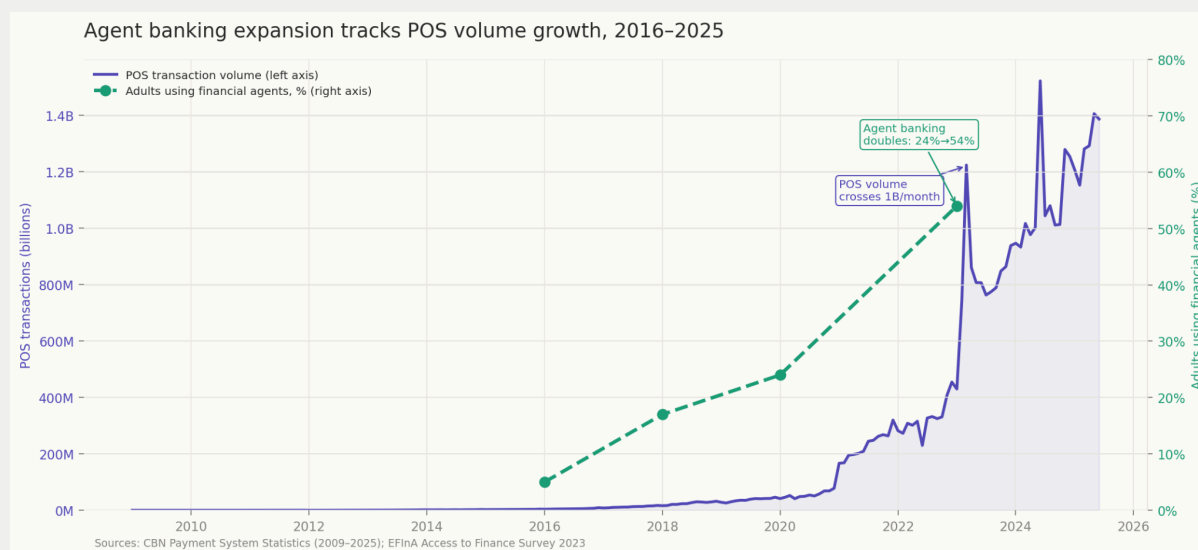
The implication is direct: the next wave of adoption does not require another crisis. It requires extending the infrastructure into the segments that the current network has not yet fully reached, and designing the right trigger — whether that is product incentives, income formalization, or credit access — to convert those segments from occasional to habitual digital payment users.

Section 2: Merchant Behavior and the Maturity Model

The numbers driving Nigeria's POS explosion do not come from a gradual shift in individual habits. They come from a structural expansion of who has access to the payment system at all — and agent banking is the mechanism that made it happen. Understanding how that expansion has played out geographically, and where it is still incomplete, is the key to answering where the next wave comes from.

2.1 The Agent Banking Inflection

Figure 4: Agent Banking Expansion Tracks POS Volume Growth 2016-2025



Source: CBN Payment System Statistics [1]; EFInA Access to Finance Survey 2023 [2]

Between 2020 and 2023, the proportion of Nigerian adults using financial service agents doubled — from 24% to 54%, reaching 60 million people [2]. Figure 4 overlays this agent banking adoption curve against the CBN POS volume data, and the relationship is immediately visible. The two lines rise together. This is not a coincidence of timing — it is a description of causality.

Agent banking works by placing POS-enabled individuals inside communities as service providers. When an agent deploys in a market, the merchants and residents around that agent gain a digital payment touchpoint that did not previously exist. They do not need bank accounts. They do not need smartphones. They need only the agent and a reason to transact. The 60 million Nigerians now reached by financial agents represent the infrastructure layer that made the 2021 and 2023 POS surges possible and permanent.

60M

Adults reached by
agents in 2023

Up from 29.2 million in 2020. Agent banking is now the primary driver of formal financial inclusion growth in Nigeria, outpacing traditional bank branch expansion by a factor that is not close. [2]

The EFInA data further shows that 10.8 million formally included Nigerians — people counted as part of the financial system — have no bank account at all and access formal finance exclusively through financial service agents [2]. This population is not a rounding error. It is the leading edge of financial system entry for millions of Nigerians, and the agent terminal is their first and only digital touchpoint.

2.2 A Digital Payment Maturity Model for Nigeria

The EFInA geographic data reveals that Nigeria is not one digital payment market — it is at least three, operating simultaneously at different stages of maturity. The formal financial inclusion rate ranges from 98% in Lagos State to 32% in Borno State [2] — a 66-percentage-point gap within a single country. The following maturity framework maps this heterogeneity.

Stage 1 — Cash-Dominant Markets

Stage 1 markets are characterized by formal financial exclusion rates above 40%, limited agent network density, and predominantly cash-based merchant behavior. POS usage exists but is episodic and agent-dependent rather than habitual. The North-West and North-East geopolitical zones represent the clearest Stage 1 profile.

The North-West records a financial inclusion rate of just 33%, with a formal exclusion rate of 47% — meaning nearly half of all adults in the region have no access to any regulated financial service. Borno, Sokoto, Zamfara, Kano, Katsina, and Kebbi states each have formal exclusion rates of at least 50% [2]. The North-East stands at 38% exclusion. Together, these two regions account for 56% of Nigeria's entire formally excluded population — approximately 18.7 million people.

Opportunity Quantification

The North-West and North-East alone contain 18.7 million formally excluded adults. At Nigeria's current average transaction frequency among new digital payment adopters, bringing even 20% of this population into regular digital payment use would represent hundreds of millions of additional monthly transactions — a transformative market expansion.

Stage 2 — Transition Markets

Stage 2 markets are in active transition: formal inclusion rates between 50% and 80%, growing agent networks, and rising but inconsistent digital payment behavior. North-Central falls squarely in this band at 60% inclusion [2]. Parts of the South-East also exhibit Stage 2 characteristics, having recorded a notable decline in its banked population between 2020 and 2023 despite gains in non-bank access — a signal of structural economic pressure on formal banking uptake even as alternative channels expand.

These are markets where the infrastructure is arriving but behavioral adoption lags. The rural-urban financial inclusion gap narrowed from 30 percentage points in 2020 to 20

percentage points in 2023 [2] — driven almost entirely by agent network penetration into peri-urban and semi-rural areas that were previously unreachable. The gap is closing, but the speed of closure depends directly on agent density and product relevance.

Stage 3 — Digital-First Markets

Stage 3 markets exhibit digital-first characteristics: formal inclusion rates above 80%, high agent density, normalized digital payment behavior across merchant categories, and rising demand for financial products beyond basic transactions. The South-West leads at 95% overall inclusion, with Lagos recording 98% formal inclusion — the highest of any state. The South-South follows at 90% inclusion, reaching 13.4 million adults [2].

In Stage 3 markets, POS terminals are not a novelty but an expected fixture of commerce. The competitive question here is not adoption but deepening — moving users from basic point-of-sale transactions toward credit facilities, business savings products, merchant analytics, and supply chain financing. The market is saturated at the access level; differentiation happens at the product depth level.

2.3 The Behavioral Insight: What Makes Adoption Stick

The Naira redesign crisis provides the closest thing available in Nigeria's payment data to a controlled experiment in adoption triggers. The crisis hit all regions, but the permanence of adoption varied dramatically by existing infrastructure density.

In Stage 3 markets where agent networks were already dense, the crisis converted marginal users — people who had access to agents but had not formed the habit — into regular digital payment users. The infrastructure was there to catch the forced behavior and convert it into routine. In Stage 1 markets with sparse agent coverage, the crisis caused temporary displacement toward whatever digital options were available, but without the infrastructure to support continued digital behavior, many users reverted to cash once the crisis eased.

The lesson is clear: infrastructure density is the prerequisite for durable adoption. You cannot trigger habit formation in a market that lacks the touchpoints to support it. The 2023 data shows that where agents existed, adoption stuck. Where they did not, it did not.

This finding has a direct forward implication. The next adoption wave does not require another crisis. It requires expanding agent network density into Stage 1 and lower Stage 2 markets to the threshold at which a less dramatic trigger — income formalization, a product incentive, a government payment — can produce the same durable conversion that the 2023 crisis produced in markets where the infrastructure was already present.

2.4 So What for Nigeria's Digital Payment Operators?

The maturity model reveals a three-speed country. Stage 3 markets are competed and require product depth, not distribution breadth. Stage 2 markets are the current frontier — growing, reachable, and responsive to investment in agent density and product relevance. Stage 1 markets are the long-term opportunity, requiring patient infrastructure investment before behavioral triggers can generate returns.

For any company operating agent networks and merchant financial services in Nigeria, the strategic implication is that the geographic allocation of infrastructure investment determines the

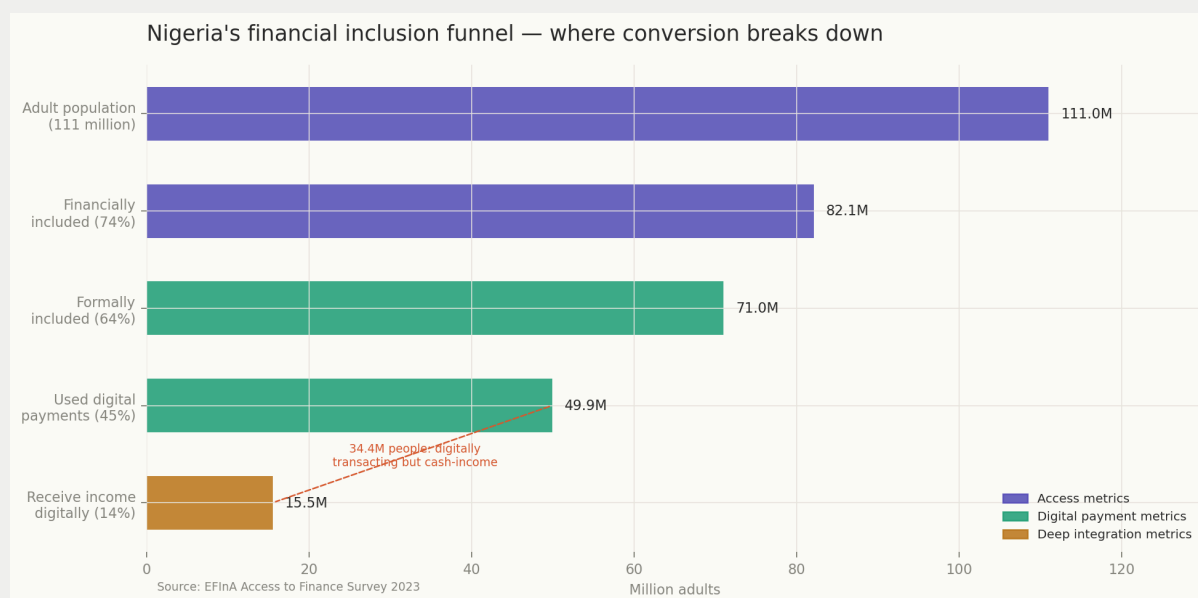
shape of growth. Companies that prioritize Stage 2 market penetration now are building the distribution advantage that will determine Stage 1 market outcomes in three to five years.

Section 3: The Inclusion Context

Nigeria's digital payment growth is real, measurable, and significant. The preceding two sections have documented it in detail. But the same data that shows 1.38 billion monthly POS transactions in June 2025 also shows that 97% of payment occasions still involve cash, and that 28.9 million Nigerian adults remain entirely outside the financial system. Understanding this paradox — growth and exclusion coexisting at scale — is essential for evaluating what the numbers actually mean.

3.1 The Financial Inclusion Funnel

Figure 5: Nigeria's Financial Inclusion Funnel — Where Conversion Breaks Down



Source: EFINA Access to Finance Survey 2023 [2]

Figure 5 visualizes the conversion breakdown across Nigeria's 111 million adult population. Financial inclusion — defined as access to any formal or informal financial product — reached 74% in 2023, up from 68% in 2020 [2]. Formal inclusion, meaning access to regulated financial services, reached 64%, approaching the government's National Financial Inclusion Strategy target of 65% by 2024 [2]. Ten million additional Nigerians entered the financially included universe in three years.

But the funnel narrows sharply at the transactional level. Only 45% of Nigerian adults used digital financial services in the past twelve months in 2023, up from 34% in 2020 [2]. And only 14% receive their income digitally — down marginally from the 2020 figure — meaning 86% of

adults are still paid in cash, fundamentally constraining their ability to engage with digital payment systems as a primary channel rather than an occasional supplement.

3.2 The Transactional Account Gap

The EFINA data surfaces the most consequential gap in Nigeria's financial inclusion landscape: 47% of adults — approximately 52 million people — have no transactional account of any kind [2]. No bank account, no mobile money wallet. They may be counted as formally included through agent access, cooperative membership, or insurance products, but they cannot independently receive a digital payment, cannot be paid digitally by an employer, and cannot participate in government digital transfer programs without a physical intermediary.

This group is not uniform. It includes rural farmers, informal traders, domestic workers, and seasonal laborers — populations whose income irregularity, limited documentation, and geographic distance from bank branches have historically made formal account ownership impractical. The EFINA data confirms that poverty remains the primary driver of financial exclusion: nearly 50% of unbanked adults report having no financial account because they have no, little, or irregular income [2].

47% No transactional account	52 million adults cannot receive or make digital payments independently. This is the defining conversion barrier — and the metric that determines whether Nigeria's payment growth story becomes a story about genuine financial empowerment or merely about transaction volume.
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3.3 Cash Still Dominates the Point of Purchase

Despite the remarkable growth in POS infrastructure, cash remains the dominant payment method at the point of goods and services purchase. The EFINA payment behavior data records 97% of Nigerian adults paying for goods with cash as of 2023 [2]. ATM or debit card usage for goods payments stands at 21% nationally, with a significant gender gap — 24.8% for men versus 17.2% for women [2]. Bank transfers via internet or app reach 10.1% nationally.

The USSD channel — which requires no smartphone, no data connection, and only a basic mobile phone — is used by 13.9% of adults for goods payments and represents the most accessible digital payment option for low-income and rural populations [2]. Its relatively low profile in public discussions of digital finance understates its actual reach in Nigeria's informal economy.

The persistence of cash dominance despite the explosion in POS infrastructure is not a contradiction — it reflects the fact that having access to a payment channel and habitually using it are separated by a significant behavioral and structural distance. The 45% of adults who used digital financial services in 2023 are largely the same people making POS transactions in the CBN data. The remaining 55% are the next frontier.

3.4 The Role of Non-Bank Fintechs in Closing the Gap

One of the most significant findings in the EFINA 2023 data is the emergence of digital microfinance banks — neo-banks and app-based lenders — as a new tracked category. In

2020, this category did not register in the survey. By 2023, it had reached 1 million users [2]. Mobile money usage tripled from 5% to 12% of adults over the same period [2].

The EFINA report notes that approximately 90% of the growth in formal financial inclusion between 2020 and 2023 was driven by non-bank providers — fintechs, payment service banks, and financial agents — rather than by traditional commercial banks [2]. The banked population grew by only 3.7 million despite 5 million new adults entering the adult population, meaning the commercial banking sector effectively lost ground in relative terms while the fintech and agent banking sector drove the headline inclusion numbers.

Critical Finding

Non-bank fintechs and financial agents drove ~90% of formal inclusion growth between 2020 and 2023. Traditional banks grew their customer base by 3.7 million while the adult population grew by 5 million. The financial inclusion frontier is being conquered by agents and fintechs, not branches.

3.5 So What: The Depth Problem

Nigeria's financial inclusion journey has successfully solved the first-order problem: getting people into some form of the financial system. The 74% inclusion rate and the 60 million adults reached by agents are genuine achievements. The second-order problem — converting access into genuine transactional capability, credit history, savings behavior, and financial resilience — remains largely unsolved.

The CBN's cashless policy and the agent banking expansion have extended the perimeter of the financial system. The work remaining is deepening what happens inside that perimeter. Moving 47 million people from the edge of the financial system into its functioning core requires products designed around irregular income, trust in digital systems, and financial capability — not just distribution. This is the strategic problem that defines the next phase of Nigeria's digital payment evolution.

Conclusion: The Next Wave

This report set out to answer three questions. The data has answered all three, and the answers tell a coherent story.

The next wave of digital payment adoption in Nigeria will come from Stage 1 and Stage 2 markets — the North-West, North-East, and transitional North-Central and South-East regions where 18.7 million excluded adults and tens of millions of informally included adults represent an undertapped population that existing infrastructure is only beginning to reach. These markets already contain the merchants, the commerce, and the economic activity. What they lack is sufficient agent density to make digital payments the path of least resistance.

What triggers durable adoption, the 2023 Naira crisis demonstrated definitively, is not motivation — Nigerians do not need to be convinced that digital payments work. It is infrastructure availability at the moment of need. Where agents existed when cash disappeared, adoption became permanent. Where they did not, it remained temporary. The implication for growth strategy is that infrastructure investment precedes adoption, not the other way around. Build the network first; the behavior follows.

What blocks full conversion is the transactional account gap. Forty-seven percent of Nigerian adults cannot independently participate in the digital economy because they have no account. The barrier is not primarily technological or geographical — it is economic. Irregular income, limited documentation, and low financial capability make formal account ownership feel distant from everyday survival for tens of millions of Nigerians. Solving this requires products designed around the reality of irregular income: flexible account requirements, agent-assisted onboarding, and financial tools that deliver tangible value — credit, insurance, or payment convenience — in the first interaction rather than after months of account history.

Nigeria's payment data over 16 years tells a story of infrastructure expanding to meet latent demand, policy shocks accelerating behavioral change, and the technology gap between the financially included and excluded narrowing faster than conventional banking models predicted. The question for the next 16 years is whether that narrowing reaches the remaining 28.9 million fully excluded and 52 million transactionally excluded Nigerians — or whether the growth concentrates among those already closest to the formal financial system.

For companies operating at the intersection of agent distribution and merchant financial services, this analysis suggests that the next growth phase belongs to whoever builds the infrastructure in Stage 2 markets today, designs the products that convert agent-reached populations into account-holding customers tomorrow, and understands that in Nigeria's digital payment ecosystem, volume is already solved. Depth is the frontier.

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